# 2.2.3 The Middle Way Part 1

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I want to start by reemphasizing the point that what are called the religions of the east, the ones we're discussing Hinduism, Buddhism and Chinese Taoism, they don't involve that you believe in anything specific. And they don't involve any idea obedience to commandments from above. And they don't involve any conformity to a specific ritual, although they do have rituals, but their rituals vary from country to country and from time to time. Their objective is always, not ideas, not doctrines, but a method, a method for the transformation of consciousness. That is to say, for a transformation of your sensation of who you are, and I emphasize the word sensation because it's the strongest word we have, for feeling directly. When you put your hand on the corner of a table, you have a very definite feeling. And when you are aware of existing, you also have a definite feeling. But in the view of these methods or disciplines, the ordinary person's definite feeling of the way he exists is a hallucination. To feel yourself as a separate ego. A source of action and awareness that is entirely separate and independent from the rest of the world, somehow locked up inside a bag of skin, is seen as a hallucination. That you are not a stranger in the earth, that comes into this world either as a result of a natural fluke or being a sort of spirit that comes from somewhere else altogether.

But that you in your fundamental existence, you are the total energy that constitutes this universe. Playing that it's you. Playing that it's this particular organism, and even playing that it's this particular person. Because the fundamental game of the world is a game of hide and seek. That is to say that the colossal reality, the energy that is everything, that is a unitary energy, that is one, plays at being many. At manifesting itself in all these particulars, that we call you and you and you and you and you and you and you and you and you and this and that and all around us. And it's fundamentally a game. And you can say that this goes really for all the systems that I'm talking about. It's the basis of Hinduism of Buddhism and of Taoism, this intuition.

Now today we're going to talk about Buddhism. Buddhism is an offshoot of Hinduism. You could in a way call it a reform of Hinduism, or Hinduism stripped for export. It originates in northern India, close to the area that is now Nepal, shortly after 600 Hundred B.C. there was a young prince by the name of Guatama Siddhartha, who became the man we call the Buddha/ Now the word Buddha is not a proper name, it's a title. And it's based on the Sanskrit root Budh. B.U. D.H.. Which means to be awake. And so you could say the Buddha is the man who woke up. From the dream, of life as we ordinarily take it to be. And found out. Who he was, who he is. It's curious, that this title was not something new. There was already in the whole complex of Hinduism the idea of Buddhas. Of Awakened people. And curiously, they are ranked higher than Gods. Because in the view of Hinduism even the gods or the Angels the Devas, are still–bound. On the wheel of the the sort of squirrel cage of going round and round and round in the pursuit of success. And the idea is that if you pursue something that you can call success, pleasure good, virtue which it originally of course means strength, magical power. All these positive things. You are under illusion because the positive cannot exist without the negative. To be, you only know what to be is by contrast with not to be, so is if we say now there is. A coin in the left hand, there is no coin in the right. And from this you get the idea of to be and not to

be. And you can't have the one without the other, so if you tried to pursue, to gain, the positive. And to deny get rid of the negative, it's as if you were trying to arrange everything in this room so that it was all up. And nothing was down. You can't do it, you set yourself an absolutely insoluble problem. Because the basis of life is spectrum. Consider the spectrum of colors. When you think of a spectrum in what form do you think of it most people think of it as a ribbon. With red at one end and purple at the other. But the spectrum is actually a circle. Because purple is the mixture. Of red and blue. It goes right round. And so in this way, all sensation, all feeling, all experience whatsoever, is moving through spectra. You don't only have the spectrum of color you have a spectrum of sound. You have various complex spectra of texture, of smell, of taste. And you are constantly operating through all the possible variations of experience. And it implies that you can't know one end of the spectrum without also knowing the other. So if you wanted, say your favorite color is red. And you wanted only red. And you had to exclude therefore blue and purple. Without blue and purple, you can't have red. Behind of course, all the various colors in the spectrum is the white light. And behind everything that we experience all our various sensations of sound, of color, of shape, of touch, there's the white light. And I'm using the phrase the white light, rather symbolically I don't mean it literally. But there is common to all sensations what you might call the basic sense. And if you explore back into your sensations and reduce them all to the basic sense you're on your way. To reality. To what underlies everything, to what is the ground of being, the basic energy. And to the extent that you realize this and know that you are it. You transcend, you overcome, you surpass the illusion. That you are simply. John Doe. Mary Smith. Or what have you.

So then, the Buddha, as the man who woke up, is regarded as one Buddha, among a potentiality of myriads of Buddhas. Everybody can be a Buddha, everybody has in himself the capacity to wake up from the illusion. Of being simply this separate individual. The Buddha made his doctrine very easy to understand, because in those days there wasn't very much writing being done and people committed things to memory, and so he put his doctrine or method, in various formulas, which were very easy to remember, and I'm going to explain it in those terms so that you can remember it just as well. He of course practiced the various disciplines that were offered in the Hinduism of his time. But he found in a certain way that they had become unsatisfactory. Because they had over emphasized asceticism. Had over emphasized, putting up with as much pain as you can. There was a feeling, you see, that if the problem of life is pain. Let us suffer. And this is the root of the ascetics you see, who lie on beds of nails, who hold a hand up forever and ever and ever, who eat only one banana a day who renounce sex, who do all these weird things, because they feel that if they head right into pain. And don't become afraid of it but suffer as much pain as possible, they will by this method overcome the problem of pain. And they will set themselves free from anxiety. There's a certain sense in that, as you can obviously see. Supposing for example, you have absolutely no fear of pain. You have no anxieties, you have no hang ups. How strong you would be. Nobody could stop you. You would have ultimate courage.

But the Buddha was very subtle, he is really the first historical psychologist. The great psychologist, psychotherapist, he is very subtle, because he saw, that a person who is. Fighting pain. Who is trying to get rid of pain, is still really fundamentally afraid of it.

And therefore the way of asceticism is not right, equally the way of hedonism, of seeking pleasure is not right.

So the Buddhist doctrine is called the Middle Way. Which is neither ascetic nor hedonistic. So it summed up in what are called the four Noble Truths. And the first is called Dukha. Dukha, means suffering in a very generalized sense. You could call it chronic frustration. And it is saying that life as lived by most people is dukha. Is an attempt in other words to solve insoluble problems. Try to draw a square circle you can't because the problem itself is meaningless. Try to arrange the things in this room so that they're all up and none of them down. It is meaningless, such a problem cannot ever be solved. So try to have light without dark or dark without light. It can never be solved. So the attempt to solve problems that are basically insoluble and to work at it through your whole life that is dukha.

Now he went on to analyze this that there are what we call three signs of being. The first is Dukha itself, frustration. The second is Anita, and this means; the letter A in Sanskrit at the beginning of a word is often the equivalent of our 'non' So nitya means permanent, anitya means impermanent, that every manifestation of life is impermanent. And therefore our quest to make things permanent, to straighten everything out, to get it fixed, is an impossible and insoluble problem and therefore we experience dukkha or this sense of fundamental pain and frustration as a result of trying to make things permanent. And the third sign of being is called an anatman. Now you know our from my talk on Hinduism that the word atman means self. Anatman means therefore non-self. That there is in you no real ego.

Now I've explained that already I've explained in talking about Hinduism that the idea of the ego. Is a social institution. It has no physical reality. It is simply, the ego, is your symbol of yourself. Just as the word water is a noise which symbolizes a certain liquid reality, so the idea of the ego, the role you play, who you are is not the same as your living organism. Your ego has absolutely nothing to do with the way you color your eyes, shape your body, circulate your blood. That's the real you. But it's certainly not your ego. Because you don't even know how it's done. From the standpoint of your conscious attention. So the idea of anatman is firstly that the ego isn't real, there isn't one. Now then, this then as the first truth. There is the situation that we have of frustration because we are fighting, the changingness of things. And because we don't realize that the ego, the I is unreal. The second of the four noble truths is then called Trishna. Trishna is a Sanskrit word again and is the root of our word thirst. And it's usually translated desire. But it is better translated "clinging", grabbing. Or there's an excellent modern American Slang a word, hang-up. That is exactly what Trishna is, a hang-up. Trishna now is clutching. As for example what we call smother love. When a mother is so afraid that her children may get into trouble. That she protects them excessively and as a result of this, prevents them from growing. Or when when lovers cling to each other excessively, and have to sign documents that they will curse and swear to love each other always, they are in a state of Trishna. And this is the same thing as holding on to yourself so tightly that you strangle yourself.

Now or so the second truth then about Krishna is that the cause of Dukha is Trishna. Clinging is what makes suffering. If you don't recognize that this whole world is a phantasmagoria. An in amazing illusion. A weaving of smoke. And you try to hold

onto it you see, then you start suffering, seriously suffering. Trishna is in turn based upon avidya. The same negative. Vidya. From the root vid means knowledge as in the Latin video and the English vision. Therefore is ignorance. Good gnosis. Means of course, to know, knowledge is the same thing as good Gnosis in Greek. To know so this is not to know, to ignore. To overlook.

And I explained in the first talk in this series how we ignore all kinds of things because we notice only what we think noteworthy. And therefore our vision of everything is highly selective, we pick out certain things, and say that's what's there, just as we select and notice the figure rather than the background, sometimes I draw this on the blackboard. Now ask the question, What have I drawn? What would you say? What have I drawn? The circle and the other suggestions Oh. Yeah you're getting the point. I've drawn a wall with a hole in it, you see, but ordinarily. [laughs] You've been reading my books.

So but ordinarily people see the ball the circle the ring or whatever and never think of the background. Because they ignore the background. Just as one thinks that you can have pleasure without pain. You want pleasure, the figure, and don't realize that pain is the background. So avidya is this state of restricted consciousness, restricted attention. That moves through life unaware of the fact that to be implies not to be. And vice versa.

So now the third noble truth is called Nirvana. This word means blow out. Nir is a negative word again like A. Vanna is blowing. So it's a kind of out-blowing. Now in breathing you know that breath is life. The Greek word, you may pronounce it pneauma or pneufma, is the same as spirit. And Spirit means breath in the book of Genesis when God had made the clay figurine that was later to be Adam he breathed the breath of life into its nostrils. And it became alive, because life is breath. But now, if you hold your breath, you lose it, he that would save his life will lose it. So Breathe in, Breathe in, Breathe In, get as much air as you can and Trishna cling. When you lose it.

So Nirvana means breathe out. Phew, what a relief that was. The sigh of relief, let it go. Because it will come back to you if you let it go. But if you don't let it go, you'll just suffocate. So a person in the state of nirvana is what we might call a blown out person. Like blow your mind. Let go, don't cling, and then you're in the state of nirvana. And I reemphasize the point. This is not I'm not preaching see not saying this is what you ought to do and simply pointing out a state of affairs that is so. There's no moralism in this whatsoever, it's simply pointing out like if you put your hand into the fire you'll get burned. You can get burned if you want to. That's OK but if you know the so happens that you don't want to get burned. And you don't put your hand in the fire. So in the same way if you don't want to be in a state of anxiety all the time. And again I emphasize if you like to be anxious, it's perfectly alright. See Buddhism never hurries anyone on, they say you've got all eternity through which to live in various forms. And therefore you don't have just one life in which you've got to avoid eternal damnation. You can go running around the wheel in the rat race and play that game just as long as you want to so long as you think it's fun. But if the comes a time when you don't think it's fun, you don't have to do it.

So I wouldn't say to anyone who disagrees with me and who says, 'Well I think we ought to engage the forces of evil in battle and put this world to right' and so on and so forth and arrange everything in this world so that it's all up. Try it, please, it's perfectly OK to go on doing that.

# 2.2.4 The Middle Way Part 2

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But if you see that it's futile, then you can let go. Don't try to cling. Relax. And if you do that, you're in the state of nirvana. And you become a Buddha. And of course it means that you become a rather astonishing person. You may of course be subtle about it and make like you're a very ordinary person. So that you don't, get people mixed up. And so in Buddhism the Buddha explained that his doctrine, his method, was a raft. It's sometimes called a yana, the word y-a-n-a, yana, means a vehicle a conveyance. And when you cross a river on a raft, and you get to the other shore, you don't pick up the raft and carried on your back you leave it behind. But people who are what I would call hooked on religion, are always on the raft. They are going back and forth, back and forth, back and forth on the raft, so that clergyman tends to turn into a ferryman who is always on the raft and never gets over to the other shore himself.

Now something to be said for that because how we going to get the raft back to the first shot to bring over the other people see somebody has to volunteer to take the back journey. But he must be awfully careful to realise that the real objective is to get the people across and set them free. If you dedicate yourself to ferrying people across. Don't ask them to come back on the raft with you. Because you get overcrowded and people will think that the raft is the goal rather than the other shore. So when I find this in in actual practice that when clergyman. Do not ever ask for money, and it's all right, you know like a doctor who simply charges a fee says, 'You come to me you pay me so much.' But the clergyman says he doesn't say pay me so much he says 'We would like your pledge your voluntary contribution.' You see, then nobody knows what to give you.

As the idea of the rot now then the fourth noble truth is called Marga. This word means 'path'. And. The way of Buddhism is often called the Noble Eightfold Path. Because there are eight. Phases I won't say steps because they're not sequential. And samyak is a very curious phrase. [It] doesn't mean right in our sense of correct some is the same really as our word sum total complete. All inclusive. We might say we might use the word integrated as when we say a person has integrity. That every person has integrity we mean is all of a piece. He's not divided against himself. So in this sense of Samyak. Dirshi. This is related to the word. Darshan. Which means a point of view, or viewing when you go to visit a great guru or teacher you have that you look at [him]. And you offer your reverence to. Many senses of it but it means simply 'to view' Look at the view. So the summing up Darshan is the complete view. For example let's take the constellation called the Big Dipper. We look at it from a fairly restricted zone in space. And it always seems whatever the season of the year, because we're so far away from it that the stars in the Big Dipper in the same position.

But imagine looking at it from somewhere else in space altogether and those stars would not look like a Dipper. They would be in another position.

Now then, what is the true position of those stars? Don't you see, there isn't one? Because wherever you look for position of hers. You could say that the true situation of those stars is how they are looked at from all points of view all possible points of view, inside the constellation looking outwards, outside the constellation looking inwards, from everywhere and everywhere. But you see, there is no such thing as the truth. And the world, in other words, is not existing independently of those who witness it. Because the world is precisely the relationship between the world and its witnesses. And so if there are no eyes, in this world the sun doesn't make any light. Nor do the stars.

So what is? is a relationship. You can, for example, prop up two sticks by leaning them against each other and they will stand. But only by depending on each other. Take one away and the other falls. So, in Buddhism it is taught that everything in this universe depends on everything else. That we have a kind of a huge network and this is called the doctrine of mutual interdependence. All of it hangs on you. And you can on all of it. Just as the two sticks support each other. And this is conveyed in a symbol which is called Indra's net. Imagine a multidimensional spider's web. In the early morning, covered with dew drops. And every drop contains the reflection of all the other do drops. And in each reflected you drop the reflections of all the other do drops in that reflection and so at infinite. That is the Buddhist conception of the of the universe in an image. The Japanese call that jijimuge. Ji. Means a thing event. A happening. So. Between happening and happening. There is no gap. In separation. Jijimuge.

Now so the first phase of the Eightfold Path has to do with one's view understanding of the world. The second phase has to do with action. How you act. Buddhist idea of ethics is based on expediency. If you are engaged in the way of liberation. And you want to clarify your consciousness. Doing that is inconsistent with certain kinds of action. So every Buddhist makes five vows. Five precepts. And you may perhaps have heard the Buddhist formula of taking what is called pancha sila [sic] five precepts. And they take what are called Sana the three refuges and the five precepts the refuges are the Buddha. The Dharma, the doctrine and the Sangha, the fellowship of all those who are on the way. So, the priest, the bhikku, the Buddhist monk. And the laypeople will chant the formula [sings] Those are the three refuges the border the Dharma and the Sangha. Then they take the five precepts. [sings] So they take these five precepts but are they part of. I undertake the precept to abstain from taking life. Adinadana. I undertake the precept to abstain from taking what is not given. Come as a mature heart. I undertake the precept to abstain from exploiting the passions. Of other I undertake the precept to abstain from falsifying speech. So that I marry a magical mother Tana I undertake the precept to abstain from being intoxicated by Sora, Mariya and much of a mother tongue or whatever they were.[laughs] I presume tardy which is alcohol. I don't know I don't know what else it was nobody does know. Because you see if you start killing people. Or taking life you're in trouble you set up an opposition and you've got to become involved in taking care of it. If you start stealing you worry people you upset people's orientation in life because if you suddenly come into the back home for dinner and find somebody stolen your table, where you going to serve dinner? If you exploited your passions it means that when

you are when you feel bored, and somehow that life is a little bit empty, you say well our what are we going to do this evening let's go and get stuffed. The A lot of people who suffer from the the city are trying to simply fill their empty psyche by stuffing themselves with food was the wrong cure.

So, likewise Musavada, if you start telling lies to everybody you know what happens when you start telling lies you have to tell extra lies to cover up the first one and you get into the most hopelessness understanding, speech collapses. And of course, the intoxication is the same problem as the exploitation of the passions. So there's a purely kind of, practical, expedient utilitarian approach to morals. There's another side to this, which doesn't enters into the into the precepts, which I will explain later.

So, that's the third phase of the Eightfold Path, then, now the second phase then, the third thing is has to do with your mind, with your state of consciousness. And this has to do with what we would ordinarily call meditation. There are the two final, the seventh and eighth aspects. Of the part. I called Samyak Samadhi and Samyak Sriti. Sriti means recollection. That's the best English word for it. Now do you understand the word recollect. Is to gather together what has been scattered. What is the opposite of remember. Obviously dismember. What has been chopped up. And scattered becomes really remembered. So in the Christian scheme do this in remembrance of me. You see the Christ has been sacrificed. Chopped up. But the mass is celebrated in remembrance. One of the old litigious says the wheat which has been scattered all over the hills, and grows up, is gathered again into the bread. Remembered. Go back to your Hindu basis. The world is regarded as the Dismemberment of the Self, the Brahman, the Godhead. The one is dismembered into the many. So remembrance, is realizing again that each single member of the many is really the one. So that's re-collection. You can think of it too in another way and it's really the same way if you think it through I'm going to leave you with a few puzzles. So that you can think them through and I want to explain. That Another way is to be recollected. Is to be completely here and now, are you here and now? Are you really here? There was a wise old boy who used to give lectures on these things, and he would get up and not say a word and he would just look at the audience. And he'd examine every person individually. And they're all start feeling uncomfortable. He wouldn't say anything, he'd look at them all. And then he had sudden he'd yell 'Wake up!' You're all asleep. And if you don't wake up I won't give you any lecture. Are you here recollected. See most people aren't there bothering about yesterday and wanting what they're going to do tomorrow. And I and all here that's a definition of sanity, to be all there.

So to be recollected, is to be completely alert. Available for the present. Because that's the only place that you are ever going to be in. Yesterday doesn't exist, tomorrow never comes. There is only today. A great Sanskrit sort of invocation says 'Look to this day, for it is life. In its brief because lie all the realities of our existence. Yesterday is but a memory. Tomorrow is only a vision. Look well then to this day. Such is the salutation of the dawn.'

So Smriti means then, recollected this in the sense of being all here. In the sense that this is the only only where there is. Then beyond that comes Samadhi. Again, notice the presence of this word S.A.M. Sam. Somebody who is. Integrated

consciousness in which there is no further separation between the know and the know the subject and the object. You are what you know. Now we think, in the ordinary way, that we are the witnesses of a constantly changing panorama of experience. From which we as the knowers of this in a way stand aside. And watch it. We think of our minds as a kind of tablet upon which experience writes a record and the tablet is always there. Although the experience goes by. And eventually the experience by writing so much on the tablet wears it out. It's all scratched away and you die.

But actually, if you will investigate this and you have to experiment on this because I cannot explain it to you in words you can only find it out for yourself, there is no difference between the knower and the known. When you say, I see a sight. I feel a feeling you are using redundant language. I see implies the sight, I feel implies the feeling. Do you hear sounds? That you just hear or you can say there are sounds. Either one will do. So you will find, if you thoroughly investigate the process of experiencing, that the experiencing is the same as the experiencer. And this is the state of samadhi. I put it originally in this form, that the organism and the environment are a single behavioral process. So likewise is the knower and the known. So you as someone who is aware, and all that you are aware of, is one process. That is the state of samadhi. And you get to that state, by the practice of meditation. Everybody Buddha figure practically is seen in the sitting posture of meditation. Which is sitting down quietly, and being aware of all that goes on without comment. Without thinking about it. And when you stop categorising, verbalizing, talking to yourself, inside your head, naturally, the separations between for example no unknown self and other simply vanish. Can you point to the difference between my five fingers? Where will you put your finger if you want to point to the difference? You see the idea of difference is an abstraction. It just isn't there. In the physical world. Of course, that's not saying that the fingers are joined like ducks claws with the web. But that it's just that. They're not the same, that's an idea, they're not different, that's an idea. And these ideas. That just aren't here see. You can't point to it, can't put your finger on it. Get down to the state of affairs where you see the world free from concepts. That's what but it's mean by void, and they say the world is basically, they use the phrase Sunya. That has a meaning of like empty, void, everything is sunya. This has certainly also the meaning of of a nature of transience gotten basically it means you can't catch the world in a conceptual net. Just if you try to catch water in a net it all slips through. If you try to tie up water in a paper package or grab it in your hands it all flows through.

So, sunya doesn't really mean that the world itself, that the energy of the world is nothing at all. It means that no concept of it is valid. You cannot make any one idea or belief or doctrine or system or theory tie the thing up. So, if you go through this, and you get completely blown out. And released in or in the state of nirvana. For no reason that anybody can explain it in just as for example as I pointed out when you see that you can't change yourself you can't lift yourself up by our own bootstraps you then get a new access of psychic energy. So in exactly the same way when you get to the state of Nirvana, there wells up from within you what the Buddhists call Corona or compassion. The sense that you aren't different from everybody else, everybody else's is suffering is you are suffering. And so this tremendous sense of solidarity with all other beings arising. So that he who reaches Nirvana, doesn't as it were, withdraw into a sort of isolated piece, but is always coming back into the world

into the difficulties into the problems of life. In compassion for everyone else. You can't be saved alone. Because you're not alone.

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